

Dell XPS 14

Bold and beautiful but at a cost

Earlier this year, Dell Vice Chairman and COO Jeff Clarke was addressing a pre-CES 2026 virtual press briefing when he took everyone by surprise with just one statement- "I owe you an apology today. We didn't listen to you. You were right on branding. You guys heard that right." Now it isn't everyday that you see the Vice Chairman of a tech giant admitting their fault. And it isn't everyday that you see them making a U-turn on a decision that was passed just a year back. But Dell did exactly that with the XPS brand.

For years, the XPS lineup was the premium Windows laptop. At one point, it was even called a MacBook alternative for those looking for a Windows device that is at par with Apple's laptops. So when I got the opportunity to review the all-new XPS 14, I was intrigued.

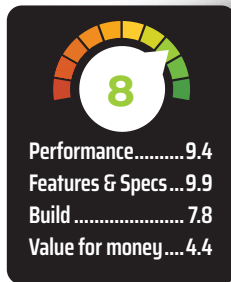
I have been using the laptop as my daily driver for more than a week. With a refined look and some mind-blowing performance, there are a lot of exciting things happening here. But, it also comes at a premium price tag. Rs 2,57,890 to be exact. So should you buy the all new XPS 14? Let's find out.

DESIGN AND BUILD

The funny thing about the XPS 14 is that when you first look at it, it almost feels... boring. It's this clean, minimal machine with a matte black finish and a subtle XPS logo sitting in the centre. The laptop demands to be carried straight to a business meeting. But, when you lift the lid, a familiar surprise awaits.

There is the familiar zero-lattice backlit keyboard, which we have seen earlier on the XPS lineup. It comes with

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an edge-to-edge design with large, flat keys placed tightly together. Typing on this thing feels firm and snappy. However, it might take a little time to get used to it if you are coming from a more traditional keyboard.

The touchpad blends seamlessly, almost hides, into the chassis and uses haptic feedback for clicks. It feels smooth, quick, and very responsive. In fact, I stopped carrying a mouse while using this laptop and that is probably the biggest compliment I can give to any laptop touchpad. The chassis also feels incredibly smooth, especially around the palm rest area.

As for the build quality, it feels rock solid. There is minimal flex on the lid and when you hold the laptop in one hand, there's a sturdiness that's reassuring. That said, the laptop is slightly heavier than what I'd like it to be but that's not a dealbreaker.

Also, the weight distribution here is excellent and I could open the laptop easily with one hand. There is also a subtle magnetic snap when you close the lid, which is just super satisfying. I

don't know why, but I kept opening and closing it for no reason.

However, ports here are very limited. You get three USB Type-C ports with Thunderbolt, a headphone jack, and that is pretty much it. I really missed having an HDMI port or even a USB-A port here. At this price point, you don't really want to be living the dongle life.

DISPLAY AND PERFORMANCE

The display on the XPS 14 is gorgeous. You get a 14-inch 2.8K OLED panel with 100 percent DCI-P3 and sRGB coverage. Now during our internal testing, we found this claim to be accurate.

In real world usage, the colours look rich and vibrant. Blacks are deep, contrast looks fantastic, and watching content is simply a treat.

At 500 nits peak brightness, this is also a bright enough display. I used the laptop outdoors quite a bit and visibility never seemed to be an issue. Now yes, because this is OLED, reflections are definitely noticeable and that can get annoying sometimes, especially under harsh lighting. PS: This is a touchscreen. Which is nice to have, but full disclosure time- I did not use it at all.

Let's now talk about the star of the show here- performance. The Intel Core Ultra X7 chip is an absolute beast and the laptop just blazed through all of our performance benchmarks.

In the 3D Mark Time Spy benchmark test, the laptop pulled up with a phenomenal score of 6045 points. This puts it way ahead of other laptops in the same price range.

And in the other 3D mark tests, a similar trend continued. Nightraid saw a score of 37494 while the Fire strike test saw a score of 11317. In wildlife and Wildlife extreme tests, the scores were 40961 and 12934.

I also ran the PC Mark 10 benchmark test. And the laptop had an overall score of 7181 with some impressive numbers in other tests. For instance, it got 10823 points in essentials, 26012 in rendering and 13632 points in Digital content creation tests. So looking at the scores,